Ironbark Repair Cafe

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY: IRONBARK REPAIR CAFE

Problem

When a household appliance or gadget stops working, most people throw it away and buy a new one. Repair is often seen as inconvenient, uncertain or more expensive than replacement, and in many neighborhoods there is simply no one nearby who will look at a broken toaster or a cracked tablet. The result is a steady stream of electronic waste and a recurring cost that falls hardest on lower-income households and renters, who can least afford to replace items that may need only a small fix. Many of these failures are minor: a loose connection, a worn cord, a dead battery, a blown fuse. Yet without access to tools, parts or knowledge, residents have few options.

A second, related problem is everyday tech confusion. Many residents, particularly older adults, struggle with slow computers, connectivity trouble and new devices, and they lack a trusted, affordable place to ask for help in person.

Solution

Ironbark Repair Cafe is a walk-in neighborhood shop where residents bring broken electronics and small appliances for low-cost repair and friendly tech troubleshooting. A customer walks in, describes the problem, and a technician diagnoses the item at the counter whenever possible. We then give a flat-rate quote before any work begins, so there are no surprises. Simple repairs are completed while the customer waits or within a few days. Items that cannot be fixed economically are recycled responsibly, and we tell the customer honestly when replacement is the better choice.

We also offer short troubleshooting sessions, booked or walk-in, for problems such as slow laptops, phone setup, printer trouble and Wi-Fi issues.

Our approach is built on three ideas: transparent pricing, a welcoming space that does not intimidate non-technical customers, and a focus on common items rather than specialized or high-end equipment.

Market

Our target customers are residents of mixed-income urban neighborhoods, especially renters, students, families on tight budgets and older adults. We believe these groups both generate frequent small repair needs and are underserved by existing options. We estimate that an average household owns dozens of small electronic devices and appliances and that a meaningful share of these fail each year. Our initial plan is to serve a single neighborhood of roughly twenty thousand residents near our university, with the goal of capturing a small percentage of households as repeat customers within the first two years. We have not yet completed a formal market study, and our sizing is based on public household statistics and informal conversations with residents and property managers. If the first location performs well, we see room to replicate the model in other neighborhoods and to add partnerships with landlords and housing organizations.

Business Model

Ironbark earns revenue in four ways. First, repair fees: flat-rate pricing by item category, ranging from roughly ten dollars for simple fixes to around sixty dollars for more involved work. Second, parts sales, with a modest markup on replacement components such as cords, batteries and switches. Third, a small monthly membership, planned at around eight dollars, that gives members discounted repairs and free basic troubleshooting. Fourth, business-to-business contracts with landlords and property managers who need appliances maintained across multiple units.

Our main costs are rent, technician labor, parts inventory, tools and insurance. We expect a typical month to require a minimum volume of repairs to cover fixed costs, and we are still refining our estimate of that break-even point. Our current assumption is that a single storefront can reach break-even at around eight to ten repairs per day, though this depends heavily on local rent and our actual average ticket size.

Competition

The space for repair is crowded and fragmented. Competitors include phone and computer repair kiosks, which focus on a narrow set of high-volume devices; appliance repair services, which typically target large appliances and charge house-call fees; big-box retailers that sell replacements and offer limited service plans; and volunteer repair events that run occasionally and cannot serve walk-in demand. Online tutorials also let some customers attempt their own repairs.

We differentiate on convenience, price transparency and scope: we handle the small, everyday items that others decline as not worth their time, in a neighborhood setting. We recognize that this niche is not defended by any strong barrier. A competitor could copy our approach, and our long-term advantage will depend on service quality, community trust and efficient operations rather than proprietary technology.

Team

Marisol Tran-Whitfield, chief executive, is a senior studying business and has run a campus electronics-swap event for two years. She leads operations and customer relationships. Devon Okafor-Reyes, head of repairs, is an engineering student who has repaired consumer electronics as a side business for several years and designed our diagnosis workflow. Priya Lindqvist, head of finance and outreach, studies accounting and manages budgeting, pricing and partnerships with local landlords and community groups. None of us has yet run a full-time retail business, and we plan to seek advice from local shop owners and our university's entrepreneurship mentors.

Milestones and Financials

We have defined our core concept and service menu, and we have built a working prototype of our intake and diagnosis process, operated out of a borrowed workspace near our university. We have formed a C corporation. Our first paying client, a local landlord, hired us to repair a batch of tenant appliances, generating our first revenue. To date, revenue is small and has come from this one customer and a few informal jobs for friends and classmates. We have not yet tracked margins carefully.

For our first year, we project modest revenue growth as word spreads, assuming a storefront opens within six months. Our early estimates suggest that a first location needs roughly forty to fifty thousand dollars to cover build-out, tools, initial parts inventory, insurance and several months of operating costs. We have no external funding at this time beyond founder contributions, and we do not yet have a website.

What We Are Asking For

We are applying to this competition for seed funding to help open our first storefront, as well as mentorship on lease negotiation, pricing and retail operations. Prize funding would let us secure space, purchase professional-grade tools and stock initial parts, moving us from a borrowed workspace to a permanent presence in the neighborhood. We would also welcome introductions to local property managers, community organizations and potential partners in electronics recycling. With this support, we aim to open within six months, validate our break-even assumptions with real data, and build a sustainable model that keeps useful products in use and money in residents' pockets.